

Baldwin's invention the first truly successful headset.

The next successful pair of headphones were made by Beyerdynamic in 1937. Dubbed the DT-48, the headphone was made available to the public and received a fair amount of success primarily because the headphones needed no other equipment to be used. It was the world's first headphone with a dynamic driver and the design was pretty advanced for the time. Unfortunately, WWII froze Beyerdynamic's production of the headphones, however, they did emerge later in the 1950s with the Beyerdynamic DT-49 headphones.

In 1939, AKG invented the K-120 headphones that received much critical acclaim due to its sound quality and design. This was also the time when people finally began considering looks as an important parameter to consider when producing or buying headphones. Until then, headphones were merely utilitarian, built for a specific purpose. As with Beyerdynamic, WWII halted the production of these headphones as well but production picked back up in the 1950s. The next development was in 1958 when John Koss, Jazz musician and audio lover, invented the Koss SP-3 headphones. They were the very first stereo over-ear headphones that revolutionised personal audio.

Home use of records began increasing and this saw an upward trajectory in the use of headphones as well. Koss dominated the US headphone market for most of the 1960s and 70s. The company cross-branded their headphones with the Beatles, creating headphones named the Beatlephones, targeted at a younger demographic. Just before this, in 1959, Stax developed the world's first pair of electrostatic headphones dubbed the SR-1. These headphones were unmatched for audio quality and clarity. In 1968, Koss also developed its first electrostatic headphones named the ESP-6 weighing a mere 2 pounds, which set a record for the lightest headset of the time.

After a brief lull in the innovations in the headphone industry, the need for portability arose giving birth



Image source: Beyerdynamic

Beyerdynamic DT-48 headphone from 1937

to one of the most iconic products in the history of headphones. It is none other than the Sony Walkman. The Walkman was a portable stereo player developed in 1979 and it came bundled with its own portable headphone – the MDR 3L2. The device caught on like wildfire and became a sensational product known for its coolness quotient. Soon other brands got into the headphone game and on-ear or supra-aural headphones became pretty popular. In the 1990s,

noise-cancelling headphones came about, allowing people to quiet out distractions when listening to music. Originally, these headphones were designed for aviators as flights often got very loud, but soon after, noise-cancelling headphones were being produced for commercial use as well. In 2000, Bose came out with its now-iconic QuietComfort lineup of noise cancelling headphones.

One of the turning points in the history of headphones was the iPod's launch in 2001 which made in-ear headphones or earbuds extremely ubiquitous and popular. The use of these earbuds became a trend due to their discrete nature, compact size, and of course, coolness quotient. However, earbuds at this time, didn't isolate very well and the volume would have to be turned up to compensate for this. In 2008, Beats by Dr. Dre revitalized the popularity of on-ear and over-ear headphones. These headphones had a lot of admirers due to its style quotient and bass-forward sound quality that worked well for popular genres at the time, such as hip-hop and rap. So, Beats and simple in-ear headphones gained massive momentum due to their consumer-friendly tuning. However, there was still a section of audiophile listeners that were



Various types of headphones on the market today